
One of the Biggest Questions of the World Cup Comes From a Country With a Unique Name

Published by

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Estimated reading time

6 min

Added on

2026-07-02

Address

<https://slate.com/culture/2026/07/bosnia-herzegovina-world-cup-soccer.html>

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Herzegovina is having a moment. Despite its accounting for half of the name of the Balkan nation Bosnia and Herzegovina, its residents have long suffered the indignity of Westerners using *Bosnia* as shorthand for the country. But something is briefly changing: Thanks to FIFA's insistence on a strict style guide—TV announcers are stating the full name, not just *Bosnia*—Herzegovina is finally getting its due. Worldwide search interest in *Bosnia* will always far outpace *Herzegovina*, but the 2026 World Cup has proved to be Herzegovina's [search breakout](#). There's a good chance that's why you're on this page. If so, welcome! Hopefully, the United States men's national team will be leading our Balkan friends by the time you read this.

One of my best friends is a Bosnian immigrant, so I've had the pleasure of meeting lots of Bosnians. Herzegovina has remained a mystery, though. The area is roughly a quarter of the country's landmass. Exactly how many people live in Herzegovina? It'd be guesswork, as this part of Bosnia and Herzegovina has no defined border. The region's biggest city, Mostar, is only the sixth-most-populous nationwide. There's no authoritative data on how many Herzegovinians live in the U.S., only a rational conclusion that there are far fewer of them than those from elsewhere in the country. Some might identify themselves as Croatian in surveys or even use the international shorthand "Bosnian."

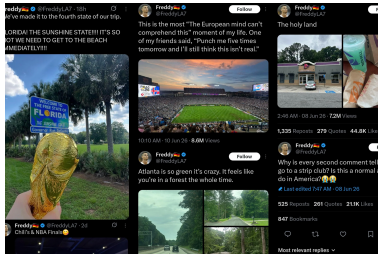
What, then, is this region's deal? It's located in the south of the nation of Bosnia and Herzegovina, and the area almost reaches the Adriatic Sea before the long southern sliver of Croatia, including Dubrovnik, interrupts it. It's not defined by one ethnic identity or a different system of governance. Given that, why are the words *and Herzegovina* attached to the most commonly uttered name of the country? These are fair questions, and in fact they were *my* questions when I called a leading Balkan historian, a Sarajevo native, this week. Now I think these are the wrong questions. The right question may in fact be: Why don't *most* countries have names like Bosnia and Herzegovina?

"If I had my perspective to convey to the larger public, it would be to start from not considering *Bosnia-Herzegovina* as an anomaly," said Edin Hajdarpašić, an associate professor who teaches about the Balkans at Loyola University Chicago. "It's a perfectly normal name for a country. If there is a strange name for a country, it would be 'the United States.' 'The United States of America'? Why are there three parts?"

Hajdarpašić is not merely being edgy. Every country larger than Vatican City is an amalgamation of places that may or may not have much in common with one another or possess one neat, shared identity. And yet, on the United Nations' [list of members](#), as close a reference as you'll find anywhere to "the world's agreed-upon names for all the countries," you can spot efforts to tidy things up. *United States* is one way to do it. (United by what? Not everything!) *Solomon Islands* is another. (Are we to presume they're all the same?) Only six countries are willing to name themselves thusly, though: Antigua and Barbuda, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Saint Kitts and Nevis, Saint Vincent and the Grenadines, São Tomé and Príncipe, and Trinidad and Tobago. *The United*

Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland nominally counts but is rarely enunciated that way, even in the most formal settings.

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“I would say a lot of misconceptions start with a starting point that views joint-compound names as somehow requiring explanation,” Hajdarpaši? said. Compound political names used to be quite normal, including for some of the world’s most powerful nations (hello, Austria-Hungary!). Hajdarpaši? points next door to Croatia, whose political identity was long discussed through Croatia, Slavonia, and Dalmatia, before *Croatia* became the dominant name and the others remained regional identities. Bosnia and Herzegovina took the road less traveled, and didn’t need the name to roll off the tongue.

That the longer name endures feels poetic, given the region’s history. Bosnia and Herzegovina was one of the six Yugoslav socialist republics, and its demography was a big mixture: Bosniaks (historically Muslim), Croats (mostly Catholic), Serbs (mostly Orthodox Christian), and more. “When Yugoslavia was dismembered by nationalist politicians starting in the late 1980s, they really focused on Bosnia as the place where communities were most diverse,” Hajdarpaši? said. “What they wanted to do is separate them. They quite literally spoke of ethnic cleansing as a means of accomplishing that.”

The ensuing Bosnian war was not exactly Bosnia against Herzegovina, so the long-form name was not about everyone getting a piece of a country that came to peace after a violent, drawn-out slog. The war pitted the internationally recognized government (Bosnia and Herzegovina, based in Sarajevo) against divisive political projects that wanted to carve the country up based on religion and kill or expel anyone who didn’t fit into their vision. This led to mass displacement and the [genocide at Srebrenica](#), for which several perpetrators were convicted at the International Criminal Tribunal for the former Yugoslavia. The country that lives on to this day, Hajdarpaši? said, is “a much more divided country than it was at any time before in its history.” There was no good reason the name needed to fracture too.

Thus far in this World Cup, the big story about American attitudes toward Bosnia and Herzegovina

was that of a TV reporter's bad joke. Seemingly trying for some lighthearted sports patriotism but overshooting her target, the announcer noted that she couldn't find Bosnia on a map. "I don't know the first thing about Bosnia, and I don't want to know. That's because, Team USA, we're back! We're better than ever." [She apologized](#), hopefully ending the saga of the bad joke and maybe even providing us the occasion to remember that we too are not immediately intelligible and understandable to the rest of the world. Hajdarpaši? says he found much about America "baffling" when he arrived as a 16-year-old during the war.

"It's an occasion for Americans, but also for everyone, to reflect on their habits or their place in the world," he said. In our moment of reflection, we might take one lesson from Bosnia and Herzegovina: A country cannot cohesively name its way to national unity, and it may well be best not to try.

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